

In search of knowledge

Do computer courses provided by private institutions actually satisfy your thirst for learning, or are they just a mirage in the desert? Nilesh Kakade speaks with representatives of AICTE and Karrox

Computer courses run by private institutes are worthwhile, provided they are run in an efficient and systematic manner, with guidelines for the students and the administration. But currently, there are dozens of 'shops' in every nook and corner of the country trying to pass off as institutes. They fleece students

Professor I.K. Bhat

Advisor, All India Council for Technical Education



As far as foreign affiliations and certifications are concerned, these certificates are legally invalid in our country. Certain universities don't even have accreditation in their parent country, and are offering courses here without any quality controls and inadequate or incompetent faculty.

AICTE is in the process of putting up detailed guidelines for a more structured system of education. This would serve as

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Courses from private institutes can be very good, provided you bear in mind the reputation of the institute and what you learn from it. Companies from the organised sector have better technological and personnel strength to back up the students' requirements than institutes from the unorganised sector, which don't have the competence to deliver.

Private companies provide several benefits to students.

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certification value and licensed software for the institute. It also shows the institute's commitment to students, as it has to pay substantial affiliation fees with stringent renewal terms.

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Jitendra Nair

VP (Software and Education Division), Karrox International



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by charging hefty fees for makeshift courses.

For instance, if they sense a demand, they will go ahead and teach a 'career-oriented' course, without the required infrastructure. Classic examples are institutes such as Wintech and Zap, which published full-page advertisements in the media and later shut shop, leaving many a student in the lurch.

Moreover, the quality of training in many private institutes is not up to the mark. The faculty often comprises ex-students of the institute, who may themselves be unclear about the subject they are teaching.

a deterrent for people who try to create unrealistic aspirations among gullible students, while consistently failing to deliver the quality of education that is expected from them.

AICTE would like reputed corporates such as IBM, Wipro, Sun, etc to join hands with us to start modular short-term courses in the non-formal sector in a structured manner, so that our students and professionals are trained on industry-specific courses. This would reduce the retraining cost for the industry and also enhance practice-oriented teaching in institutions. ■

These include a trained faculty, customised courses tailor-made to industry needs, exposure to real time environment and pre-placements (students get jobs at the company that trains them).

Other deciding factors are the quality of training, courseware and the company's credentials and background. The technology base should also be evaluated before a student decides on an institute.

About foreign affiliations and alliances, these provide some very obvious benefits, such as certified trainers, official courseware developed by the parent company, high

recruiters may insist on BEs and BTechs, if they don't get the profile that they seek, they turn to qualified, certified professionals from private institutes.

In fact, many students at private institutes are from engineering colleges, indicating that latest software technology training from private institutes has become indispensable.

The steps taken by AICTE are very encouraging. This will make all institutes answerable to a particular body. But while conceptually it is a very welcome sign, its implementation should be fast-paced and not get bureaucratic. ■

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Jitendra Nair on July 12 at 4 pm and I.K. Bhat on July 19 at 4 pm

